RMIT UNIVERSITY School of English & University Pathways

Helping students access additional support

Practical guide for subject lecturers | D17-S1

Make referrals specific and practical so students understand why a service may help and how to use it. Continue the subject teaching and clarification that remain your responsibility. A referral should help students take a manageable next step.

How to make a practical referral

- Speak privately and refer to a particular piece of work or learning task. Ask how the student sees the difficulty.
- Identify a strength and describe one difficulty clearly. Avoid general statements such as “Your English is weak”.
- Check which current service fits the issue. Language development, subject knowledge, access and wellbeing concerns may need different support.
- Explain what the service does, how to book or make contact, and what to bring. Check eligibility and costs if relevant.
- Ask the student to describe the next step in their own words. Offer help locating the booking page if needed.
- Agree when to check back. Ask whether the support was useful and what still needs attention; continue relevant subject support.

Example conversation

“Your evidence is relevant to the question. I could not always follow the links between your points. How did you find writing this section? A writing consultation could help you practise making those links clear. Bring this draft and the assignment brief. Let us open the booking page together. I can clarify the subject argument with you during our course consultation.”

Set realistic expectations

Explain that a consultation helps students develop their work and strategies. Check the actual service description before promising editing, proofreading or a particular result. Support may be most useful across several visits.

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Referral preparation checklist

- The specific difficulty and an example from the work are clear.
- The student has had a chance to explain their experience.
- The service is appropriate and its current contact details are verified.
- The student knows the booking steps and what to bring.
- A follow up point and ongoing subject support are clear.

Adaptable referral message

“In [task], you showed strength in [specific strength]. The next area to work on is [specific difficulty]. [Service] can help with [confirmed purpose]. You can contact or book through [current link or location]. Bring [relevant materials]. We can check how this is going at [agreed point]. For questions about [subject issue], continue to contact me through [course route].”

Follow up without pressure

Ask “Were you able to contact the service?” and “Was it useful for the issue we discussed?” If access was difficult, help identify a workable route. Avoid asking students to disclose confidential consultation details.

Local information to complete

Record the service name, eligibility, contact route, booking instructions, relevant materials and an alternative contact if booking fails. Update these details before each course delivery.

Supporting sources

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). *Student referral best practices*